

Your 24-hour finance manager

Do you still pay your bills by mail, deposit checks at your bank branch, and prefer a personal visit to your banker, much the way your parents did? If yes, then you've either not heard about online finance services and online banking, or probably never tried it. Guess what? It's worth a try

What's the first thing that comes to your mind when you get your electricity, phone or credit card bills? Pay it! Then why are we asking you this silly question? Simply because today you have many ways of paying bills. You could physically go to BSES and MTNL offices, stand in a queue and pay the bills.

Or, you could get someone else to do it for a charge. Of course, you could use phone banking too. The third way is to log on to the Internet and pay them online. And if you choose to do this, or are doing it, then you are one among the 100 million households that now bank online. (See graph, 'Seven-and-a-half years of Web Banking')

That's not all. You can surf for a loan, life insurance or a home mortgage. You can even trade shares or shop from the comfort of your home. Online banking isn't out to change your money habits. Instead, it uses today's computer technology to skip the time-consuming, paper work of traditional banking in order to manage your finances more quickly and efficiently—it's available 24-hours, there are no queues, convenience and the like.

If you are an account holder at a bank which has a Net banking facility, you are given a Net password. You have to fill out a form

detailing your preferences after which the password is couriered to you. The courier generally contains the user ID, login password and transaction password. For security reasons, users are asked to change the login and transaction passwords after they first login. In some cases, you have to write to the bank to get your user ID enabled. On clicking the login button, your user ID and password generally travel in a secure SSL mode with 128-bit encryption (see box, 'How secure is Online banking?').

What's on offer?

While many banks offer online banking facilities, most of them do not offer up-to-the-second account information. This means that if a cheque issued by you has been debited from your account in the morning, your account status will not reflect this when you login to your account

